



2020 Summer Olympics, she had already broken new ground by becoming the first Indian woman paddler to reach the round of 32 in the singles competition.

Her achievements also include a gold medal at the 2018 Commonwealth Games, a result that helped elevate the profile of table tennis in India.

Speaking at the ceremony, Manika reflected on a small ritual that connects her performance to a deeper sense of identity.

"Good evening. Thank you so much to Sportstar and the respected jury members for honouring me.

Yes, as you mentioned, I love my country. And first of all, I am a girl who loves nail paint. But I also love my country, and that's why I paint the Indian tricolour on my nails. When I play and look at it during my serves, seeing the tricolour motivates me."

Rani's journey mirrors the rise of Indian women's hockey itself. One of the finest forwards to wear the national jersey, she retired from

international hockey in 2024 after a career that produced 205 goals in 254 appearances. Having made her debut as a 14-year-old in 2008, she went on to captain India to a historic fourth-place finish at the 2020 Summer Olympics.

Her tenure also saw India end a 13-year title drought at the Women's Hockey Asia Cup and claim a silver medal at the Asian Games.

Looking back on her journey, Rani said, "An athlete is always an athlete. Recognition like this motivates us to do even better.

"My journey was not simple. As a seven-year-old girl, in those days and in that society, saying that I wanted to play hockey was the biggest challenge. But when I look back today, those challenges were worth it. They taught me a lot."

"I never imagined that one day I would lead India at the Olympic Games. I am really proud of all the girls I played with at the Olympics. That team inspired girls from every nook and corner of the country."

Reflecting on the broader transformation of women's sport in India, Tania said, "There has never been a better time than today to dream of playing for the country. I had my first Grandmaster training camp at 19, whereas youngsters today are getting that exposure at nine."

Rani, meanwhile, emphasised the need for stronger structural support.

"I was in the UK recently, where 25 women from across the world had gathered. I was amazed to see how they support women athletes there. One athlete had a four-month-old baby, and another had a two-and-a-half-year-old. They brought their children along, and administrators were even holding the kids and telling the athletes to focus on their game.

"If we can create that culture in India too, it will help them take their talent forward and bring real change in society."